

Legacy Rails & the AI That Couldn't

Madison Sites
Staff Engineer @ Order.co



Order.co



Purchasing Platform



Order.co



Dynamic Virtual Cards



Order.co



Custom Invoicing



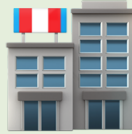
Order.co



So many vendors



Order.co





Garry Tan  
@garrytan

I think people are sleeping a bit on how much Ruby on Rails + Claude Code is a *crazy unlock* - I mean Rails was designed for people who love syntactic sugar, and LLMs are sugar fiends.

Convention Over Configuration Is LLM Catnip

Rails' entire philosophy is "there's one right way to do things". When Claude sees a Rails codebase, it knows: [@illescodraffa](#)

- Models go in `app/models/`, controllers in `app/controllers/`
- `has_many`, `belongs_to` patterns are standardized
- Service objects follow predictable patterns
- Migrations have a specific DSL
- Tests go in `test/` with predictable naming

This means Claude spends almost zero tokens figuring out *where* things go or *how* they should be structured — it just writes correct code immediately. [@networks](#)

Compare to JS/Python

JavaScript is chaos. Is it React? Next.js? Express? Nest? Bun? Deno? Every project has different folder structures, state management patterns, and build configs. Claude has to spend tokens understanding your specific setup before writing anything useful. [codeburst · 1](#)

Python is better but still fragmented — Django vs FastAPI vs Flask, different ORM choices, no standard project structure. And Python's dynamic typing plus whitespace sensitivity means more runtime errors to debug. [codeburst](#)

The Numbers

Developers report **2-3x productivity gains** with Claude Code on Rails specifically, with some calling it "orders of magnitude" improvement. Token usage drops 30-40% because Claude finds context faster in conventional codebases. One dev did **233 commits averaging 12 per day** with ~15,000 lines of code on a Rails 8 prototype. [reddit · 2](#)

Rails' opinionated nature means Claude can be autonomous longer without needing clarification — which is why your 8-phase spec can just... execute. In a JS monorepo you'd be answering "which pattern should I use for X?" questions constantly.



Davide Santangelo

Posted on Jan 15 • Edited on Jan 16



5



1



1



1



1

Why Ruby Shines in the Age of AI-Powered Development



Events

Jobs

Merch

Foundation

our agents with
ver configuration.

a fascinating new
models... T-A
and com...



Ruby on Rails scales from PROMPT to IPO. Token-efficient
that's easy for agents to write and beautiful for humans



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@garrytan

...

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8:57 AM • Feb 2, 2026 • 679.6K Views

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Performative feature flags





Competing patterns





Ruby **off** Rails





I'm the problem?





Ruby's the problem?





Oh, 💩





Oh, 💩



"The best antidote to
too much AI is more
AI."

- AI Hype Dude



"Insanity is doing the same thing over and over again, but expecting different results."

- Albert Einstein



"Insanity is doing the same thing over and over again, but expecting different results."

- Rita Mae Brown



The Experiment

A full day on a feature...



The Experiment

A full day on a feature...

1. No changes in the editor



The Experiment

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The Experiment

A full day on a feature...

1. No changes in the editor
2. The agent is a pairing partner
3. **Compile agent-generated guidelines**



~~agents.md~~





docs/pi-pod/🥧



Code Style & Best Practices

Avoid Callbacks When Possible

Prefer **explicit service orchestration over Rails callbacks** for business logic. Callbacks make code harder to test, debug, and reason about.

✅ Good - explicit service orchestration:

```
# Controller
class PostsController < ApplicationController
  def create
    @post = Post.new(post_params)

    if @post.save
      # Explicit business logic orchestration - clear and testable
      Posts::Commands::SendNotifications.call(post: @post)
      Posts::Commands::UpdateSearchIndex.call(post: @post)
      Posts::Commands::TrackAnalytics.call(post: @post, event: :created)

      redirect_to @post
    else
      render :new
    end
  end
end

# Service that orchestrates multiple operations
class Posts::Commands::PublishPost
  def call
    return unless can_publish?

    post.update!(status: :published, published_at: Time.current)
```



```
def send_notifications
  Posts::Commands::SendNotifications.call(post: post)
end

def update_search_index
  Posts::Commands::UpdateSearchIndex.call(post: post)
end
end
```

✗ Bad - hidden callback logic:

```
# Model with callbacks - harder to test and debug
class Post < ApplicationRecord
  after_create :send_notifications
  after_update :update_search_index, if: :published?
  after_commit :track_analytics

  private

  def send_notifications
    # Hidden business logic that's hard to test in isolation
    NotificationService.new(self).send_to_subscribers
  end

  def update_search_index
    # More hidden logic with unclear dependencies
  end
end
```



```
def create
  @post = Post.new(post_params)
  @post.save # Hidden side effects happen here
end
```

Why avoid callbacks:

- **Explicit dependencies** - you can see what operations happen when
- **Easier testing** - test services in isolation without triggering unrelated callbacks
- **Better debugging** - clear call stack when issues arise
- **Conditional logic** - easier to add conditions around when operations should run
- **Error handling** - can handle failures from different operations appropriately
- **Performance** - avoid running expensive operations when they're not needed

When callbacks might be acceptable:

- **Data integrity operations** that should always happen (e.g., `before_validation :normalize_email`)
- **Simple data transformations** with no external dependencies
- **Auditing or logging** that doesn't affect business logic flow

Dynamic Configuration Patterns

Make services flexible through configuration rather than hard-coding behavior



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Service Development Guidelines

When creating or working with service objects, follow these patterns.

Reference Files:

- `app/services/invoicing/builders/consolidated.rb` - Example of well-structured service with logging
- `spec/services/invoicing/builders/consolidated_spec.rb` - Corresponding test structure



Contributing to These Guidelines

See [contributions.md](#) for documentation standards and example guidelines.



Service Structure

Use the `Callable` (`app/services/callable.rb`) pattern for service objects:

```
class Blogs::Services::PostCreator
  extend Callable

  def initialize(title:, content:, author:, publish_immediately: false)
    @title = title
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Documentation Standards

When adding examples to any guideline document in this directory, follow these standards:

Domain Examples

Use a distinct domain (e.g., Blog and Posts) to avoid confusion with the real codebase, while preserving context when necessary.

✓ Good Examples:

```
# Using Blog domain
class Blog::Commands::PublishPost
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# Test examples
let(:post) { create(:post, :draft) }
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The Experiment

A full day on a feature...

1. No changes in the editor
2. The agent is a pairing partner
3. **Update** agent-generated guidelines



"Do you have any other thoughts, ideas, or concerns about what we've got so far?"

- Madison, trying so hard



/pi-dev



/pi-dev

A workflow skill

1. Research jira & code domain



/pi-dev

A workflow skill

1. Research jira & code domain
2. **Propose work breakdown**



/pi-dev

A workflow skill

1. Research jira & code domain
2. Propose work breakdown
3. **Do the things**



/pi-dev

A workflow skill

1. Research jira & code domain
2. Propose work breakdown
3. **Per commit/work/chunk**
 - a. 🚦



/pi-dev

A workflow skill

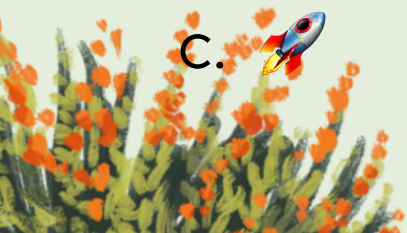
1. Research
2. Work breakdown
3. Do the things
 - a. Write failing tests
 - b. 👍



/pi-dev

A workflow skill

1. Research
2. Work breakdown
3. Do the things
 - a. Write failing tests
 - b. Human-approved tests
 - c. 

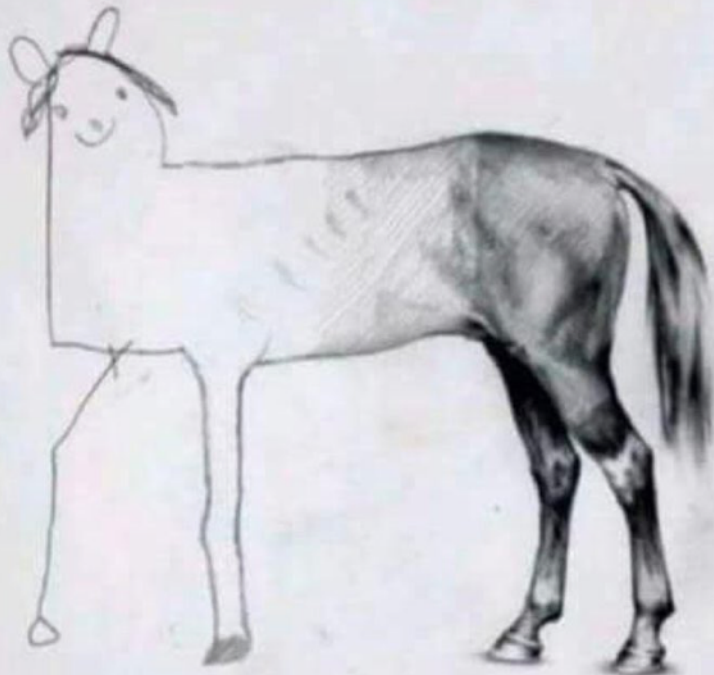


```
1 ---
2 name: pi-dev
3 description: "Test-first development workflow for F
  gate. Use when implementing features, fixing bugs,
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5 ---
```





“Full Stack”
Developer



“Don’t concern your little engineering brain with token costs”

- Leadership, sort of



The Forage

Mine while tokens are cheap 🛠️

1. Trusted source



The Forage

Mine while tokens are cheap 🛠️

1. Trusted expert
- 2. Timely info**



The Forage

Mine while tokens are cheap 🛠️

1. Trusted expert
2. Timely info
3. **Quality reviewer**



“🤖, fetch me all those
quality front end PR
comments from the
last 6 months...

...distill all that into the
guidelines”

- Madison, feeling sMaRt





 #4901 

 Merged

 merged 16 commits into [development](#) from   on Nov 7, 2018

 Conversation 0

 Commits 16

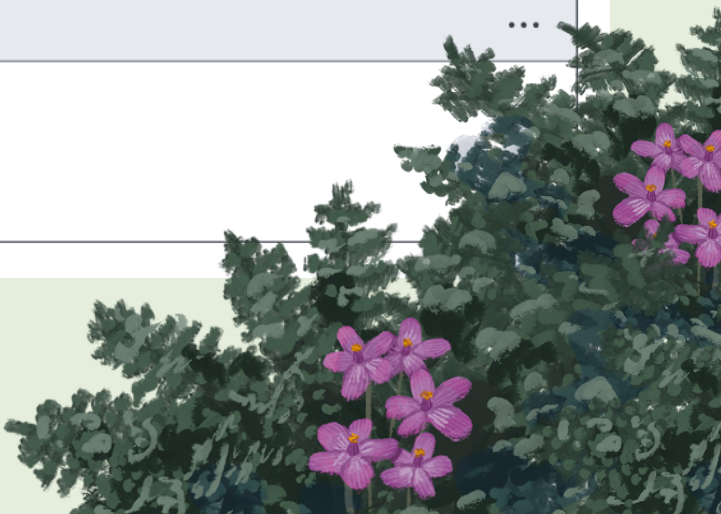
 Checks 0

 Files changed 9



 commented on Nov 5, 2018 

No description provided.





 #4901 

 Merged  merged 16 commits into `development` from   on Nov 7, 2018

 Conversation 0  Commits 16  Checks 0  Files changed 9

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No description provided.







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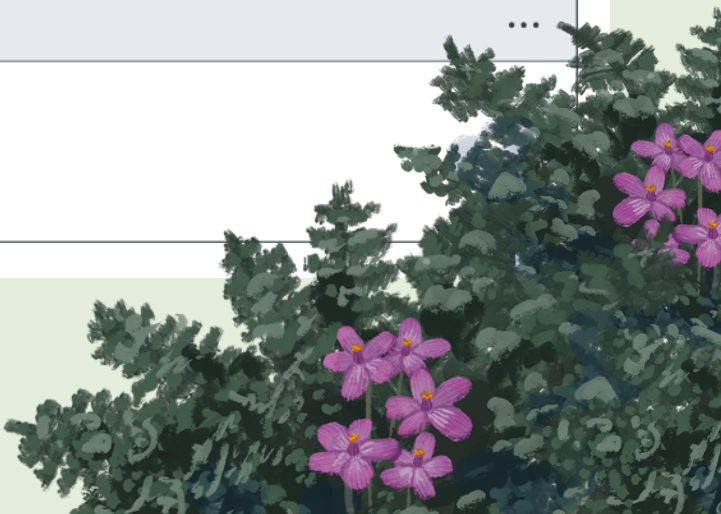
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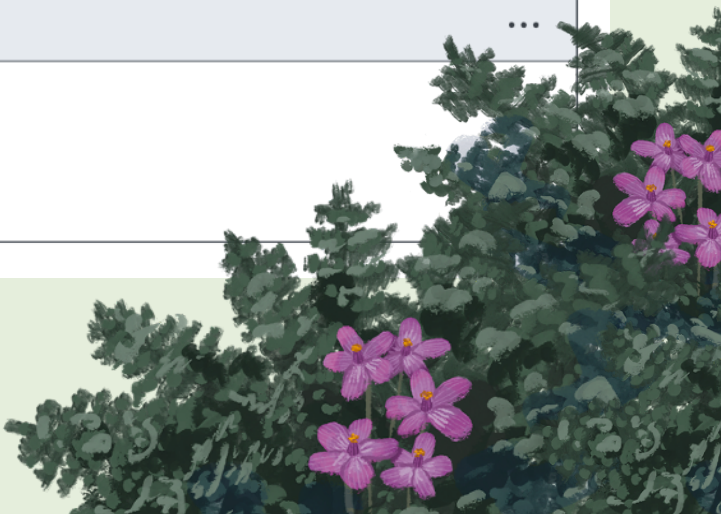
 Checks 0

 Files changed 9



 commented on Nov 5, 2018 

No description provided.





Refactor bulk tracking import #9897

 Merged

 merged 9 commits into `master` from   on Dec 20, 2022



Conversation **32**



Commits **9**



Checks **0**

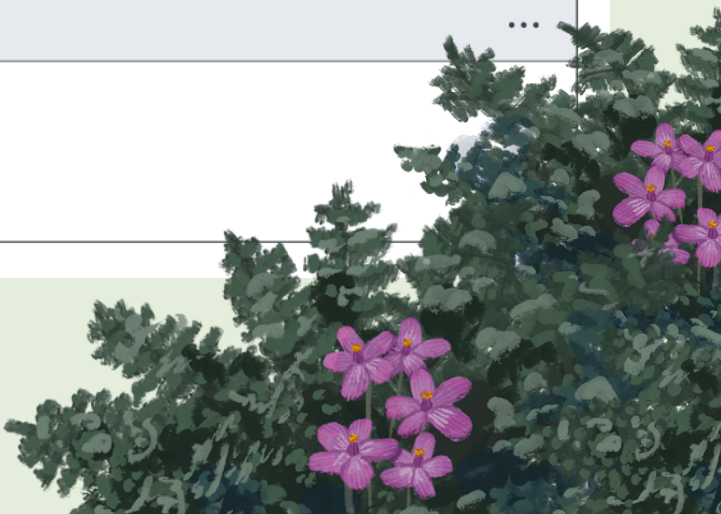


Files changed **17**



   commented on Dec 17, 2022 

WIP





Refactor bulk tracking import #9897

 Merged

 merged 9 commits into `master` from  on Dec 20, 2022



Conversation 32



Commits 9



Checks 0



Files changed 17



 commented on Dec 17, 2022 

WIP





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Conversation 32



Commits 9



Checks 0



Files changed 17



 commented on Dec 17, 2022 

WIP





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Conversation 32



Commits 9



Checks 0



Files changed 17



 commented on Dec 17, 2022 

WIP





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Conversation **32**



Commits **9**



Checks **0**

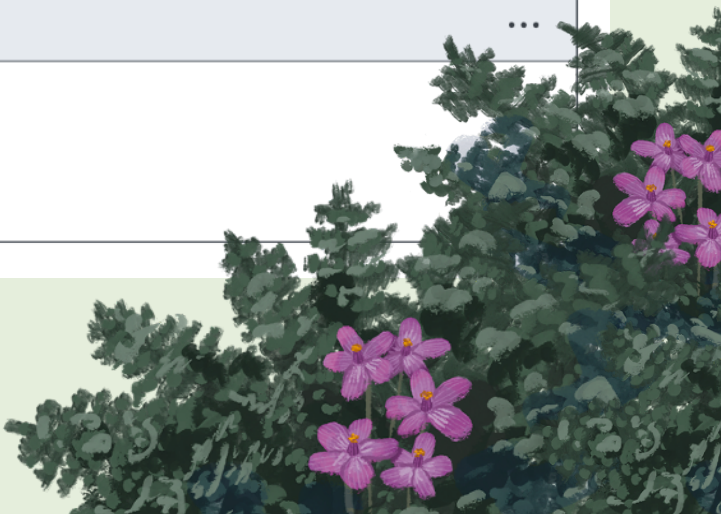


Files changed **17**



   commented on Dec 17, 2022 

WIP





 #11387 

 Merged

 merged 4 commits into [master](#) from  on Dec 11, 2023



Conversation 0



Commits 4



Checks 0



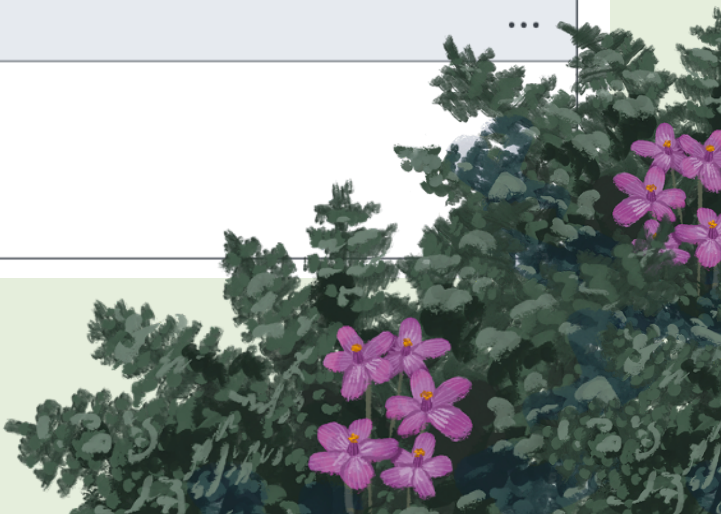
Files changed 23

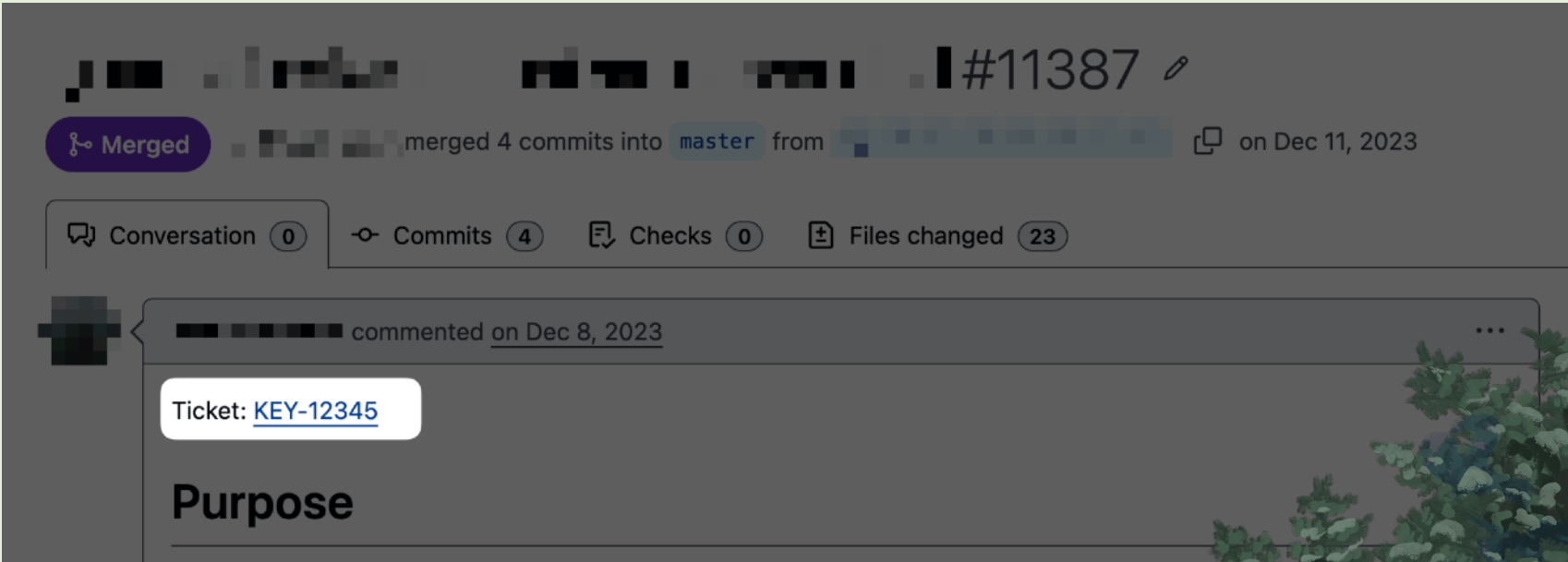


 commented [on Dec 8, 2023](#) 

Ticket: [KEY-12345](#)

Purpose







fix(COREX): only show warning when paused! #12835

 Merged



merged 1 commit into

master

from

fixes/corex/display-fraud-warning-for-view-only



or



Conversation 1



Commits 1



Checks 0



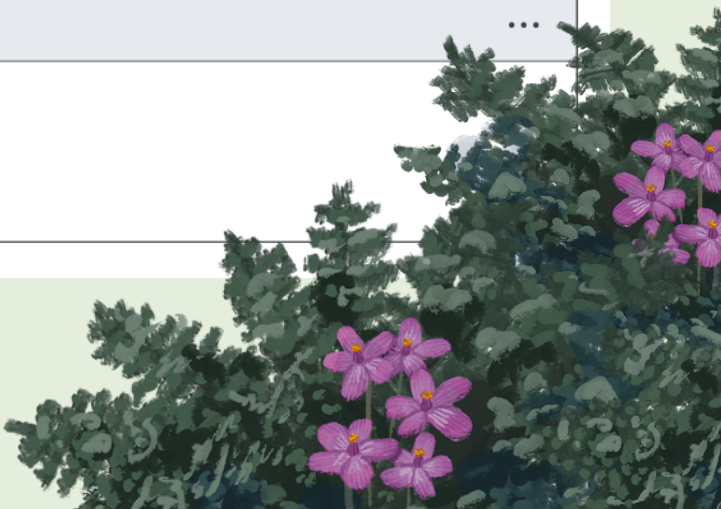
Files changed 1



commented on Nov 8, 2024



Oops





fix(COREX): only show warning when paused! #12835

 Merged



merged 1 commit into

master

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o



Conversation 1



Commits 1



Checks 0



Files changed 1



commented on Nov 8, 2024



Oops





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o



Conversation 1



Commits 1



Checks 0



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o



Conversation 1



Commits 1



Checks 0



Files changed 1



commented on Nov 8, 2024



Oops





fix the bad submodule thing #6827

 Merged

timothy ■ ■ ■ ■ merged 1 commit into `master` from `NEG0-4840/fix_the_submodule_oopsies`  on Jan 16, 2020



Conversation 1



Commits 1



Checks 0

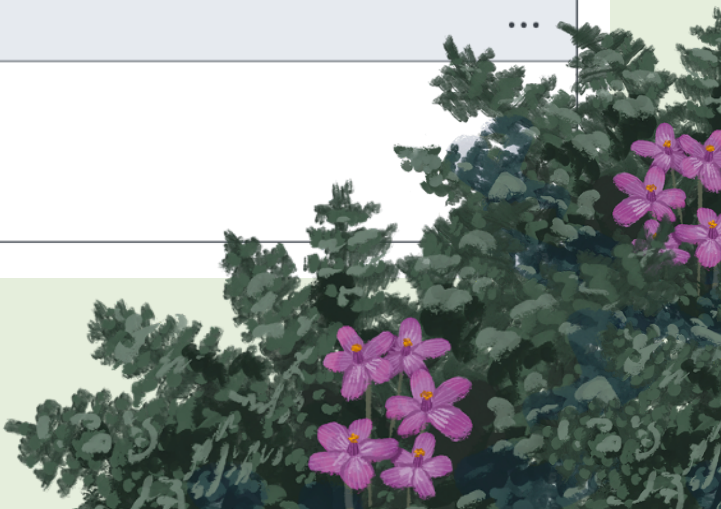


Files changed 1



■ ■ ■ ■ commented on Jan 16, 2020 

TIM knows





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Conversation 1



Commits 1



Checks 0



Files changed 1



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Conversation 1



Commits 1



Checks 0



Files changed 1



 commented on Jan 16, 2020 

TIM knows



Changes

New files:

- `app/controllers/n/payments_and_billing_controller.rb` -- hub controller with `access_billing` permission
- `app/components/payments_and_billing_index_component.rb` + ERB + locale -- hub page component rendering 4 navigation cards (Subscription, Consolidated Billing, Payment Methods, Integration Settings)
- `app/views/n/payments_and_billing/index.html.erb` -- hub view
- `config/locales/en/n/payments_and_billing.yml` -- page title locale
- `spec/controllers/n/payments_and_billing_controller_spec.rb` -- controller spec
- `spec/components/payments_and_billing_index_component_spec.rb` -- component spec

Modified files:

- `config/routes.rb` -- added `payments_and_billing` route in `namespace :n`
- `app/services/nav/acl_service.rb` -- sidebar now links to hub with expanded `active_paths`
- `app/views/n/manage/payments_and_billing/_layout.html.erb` -- replaced tabs with back-button via `@application_header`

Deleted files:

- `app/views/n/billings/_layout.html.erb` -- unused legacy tabbed layout
- `app/helpers/billings_helper.rb` -- removed `layout_nav_links`
- `spec/views/n/billings/_layout.html.erb_spec.rb` -- spec for deleted layout
- `spec/helpers/billings_helper_spec.rb` -- removed `layout_nav_links` tests



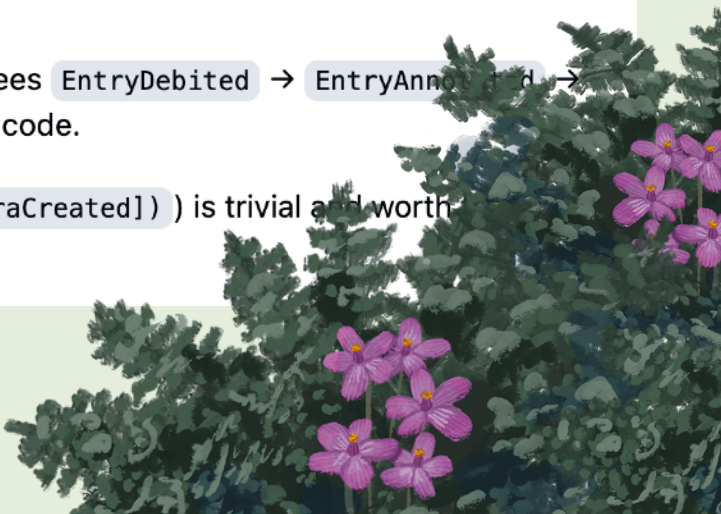


ContraCreated vs EntryCredited — business intent naming



1. Change record names should capture business intent without inspecting data. `ContraCreated` immediately tells someone "an invoice payment offset was created." `EntryCredited` would require inspecting the payload to distinguish refunds from contras from regular credits.
2. When someone browses an `Order$123` stream in the RES browser and sees `EntryDebited` → `EntryAnnoyed` → `ContraCreated`, they can read the payment story without understanding code.

The tradeoff (querying "all credits" requires `of_type([EntryCredited, ContraCreated])`) is trivial and worth diagnostic clarity.

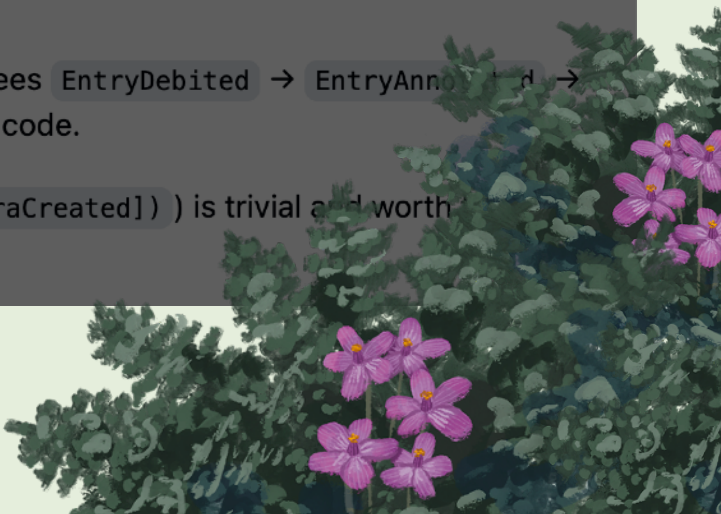




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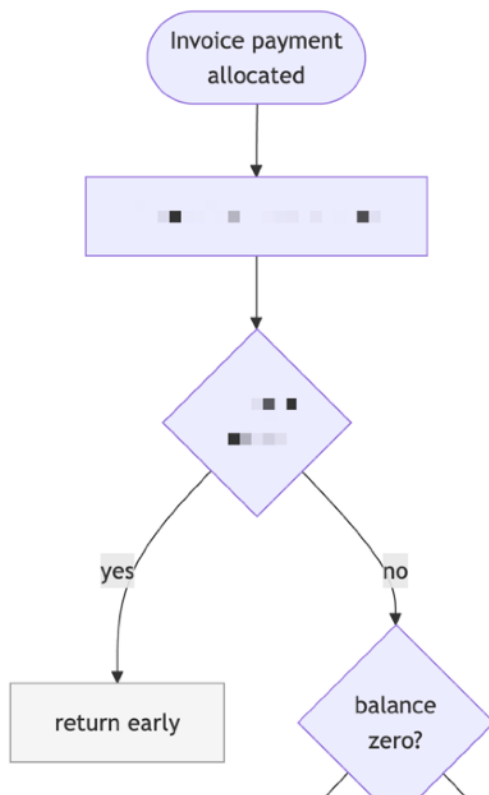
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Context

creation flow





madisonsites commented on Mar 9 • edited ▾

...

Ticket: [PI-3221](#)

Remove deprecated old-format Codat data sync handling

Purpose

- Codat [fully deprecated their legacy rules-based webhooks](#) in January 2025 — the old "Data sync completed" rule type no longer exists and all webhooks use the `read.completed` event format
- Removes the dual-format payload parsing branch that handled both old PascalCase keys (`CompanyId` , `DataConnectionId`) and the current nested structure (`payload.referenceCompanyId` , `payload.dataTypes[].connectionId`)
 - `normalize_data_sync_params` renamed to `extract_data_sync_params` since there's no longer a second format to normalize between
- Removes old-format test contexts from both `callbacks_spec.rb` and `codat_callbacks_controller_spec.rb`
 - Inlines `shared_examples` in each since only one context remains after the old-format contexts are removed
- Removes deprecated `@see` doc references to the old Codat rules-types URL



madisonsites commented on Mar 9 • edited ▾

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Test plan

- ☐ Controller spec passes: `bundle exec rspec spec/controllers/n/payments_and_billing_controller_spec.rb`
- ☐ Component spec passes: `bundle exec rspec spec/components/payments_and_billing_index_component_spec.rb`
- ☐ NavigationCardsComponent spec passes: `bundle exec rspec spec/components/navigation_cards_component_spec.rb`
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- ☐ Navigate to `/n/payments_and_billing` and verify the hub page renders 4 cards with icons to the left of text, vertically stacked
- ☐ Click Subscription card and verify sub-page loads with "Back to Payments & Billing" header; verify back button navigates to hub
- ☐ Click Consolidated Billing card and verify sub-page loads with "Back to Payments & Billing" header; verify back button navigates to hub
- ☐ Click Payment Methods card and verify sub-page loads with "Back to Payments & Billing" header; verify back button navigates to hub
- ☐ Click Integration Settings card and verify sub-page loads with "Back to Payments & Billing" header; verify back button navigates to hub
- ☐ Sidebar "Payments & Billing" item stays highlighted on hub and all sub-pages
- ☐ Integration Settings card only appears when org has linked account connection



Test plan

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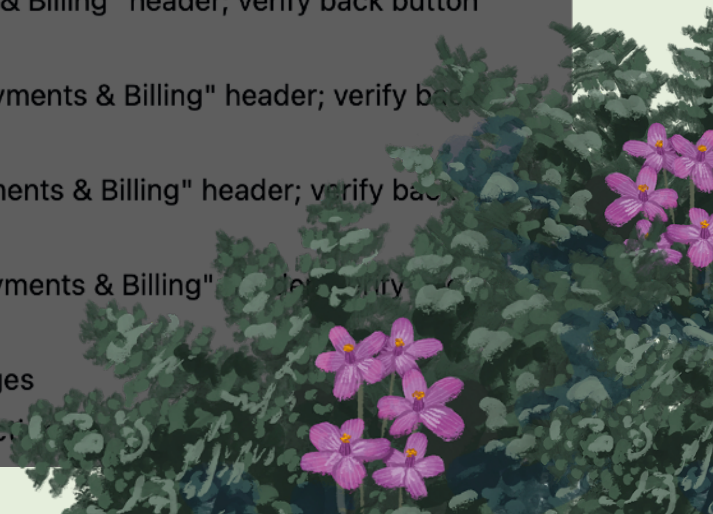
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Test plan

Setup

Toggle the feature flags in local config to test each combination:

[negotiatius/launch_darkly_local.json](#)

Lines 35 to 36 in 6e9f948

```
35   "maintenance": true,  
36   "lfc": false,
```

Invoices page (both flags ON)

Set both flags to `true` in `launch_darkly_local.json`, restart the server, then navigate to the invoices/statements page.

Expected: Credit widget shows  with no maintenance warning.

⚠️ [Add screenshot of invoices page with both flags ON] ⚠️

Invoices page (LFC OFF, maintenance ON)

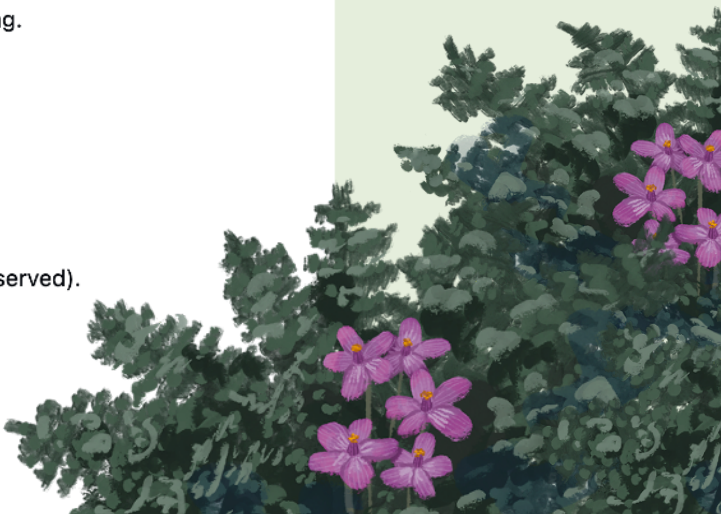
Set `lfc` to `false` and `maintenance` to `true`.

Expected: Credit widget shows the "Temporarily unavailable" warning (old behavior preserved).

⚠️ [Add screenshot of maintenance warning] ⚠️

Dashboard (LFC ON, maintenance OFF)

Set `lfc` to `true` and `maintenance` to `false`.



Test plan

Setup

Toggle the feature flags in local config to test each combination:

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Lines 35 to 36 in 6e9f948

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⚠️ [Add screenshot of invoices page with both flags ON] ⚠️

Invoices page (LFC OFF, maintenance ON)

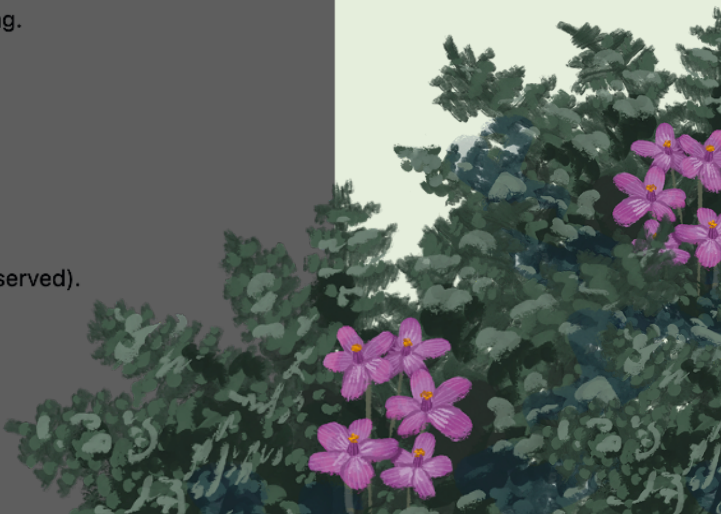
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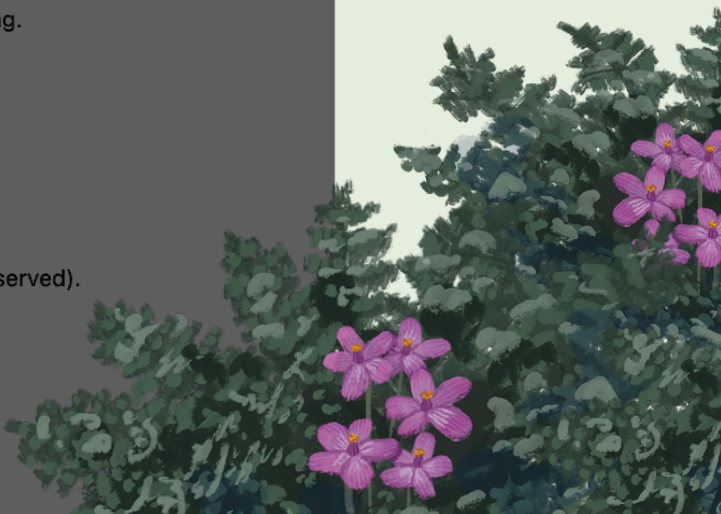
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Test plan

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[negotiatatus/launch_darkly_local.json](#)

Lines 35 to 36 in 6e9f948

```
35     "e": true,  
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```

Both flags ON

Set both flags to `true` in `launch_darkly_local.json`, restart the server, then navigate to the invoices/statements page (`http://localhost:3000/n/statements?tab=invoices`):

Invoices page

Expected: Invoices page shows the  with no maintenance warning.

Invoices

[Pay invoices](#)

You (Madison Sites) are currently signed in as **Hank Hill** of Strickland Propane. Click [here](#) to log back into your own account. ×

Current credit limit

\$18,910.65 available

\$81,417.85 used

\$100,000.00 limit

Current credit spend

\$81,089.35 net outstanding

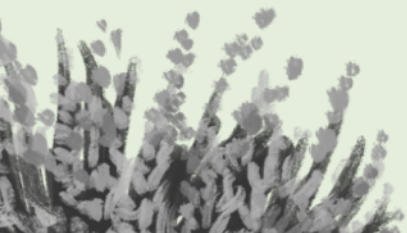
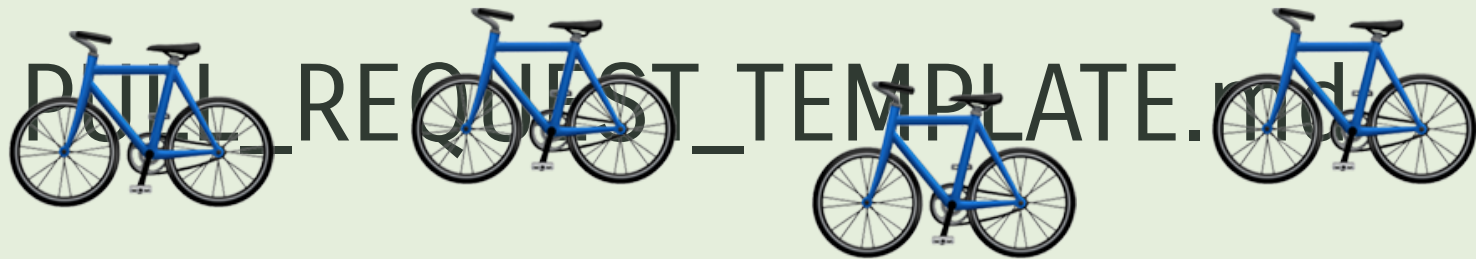
Outstanding invoices
\$66,230.61

Pending orders
\$15,187.24

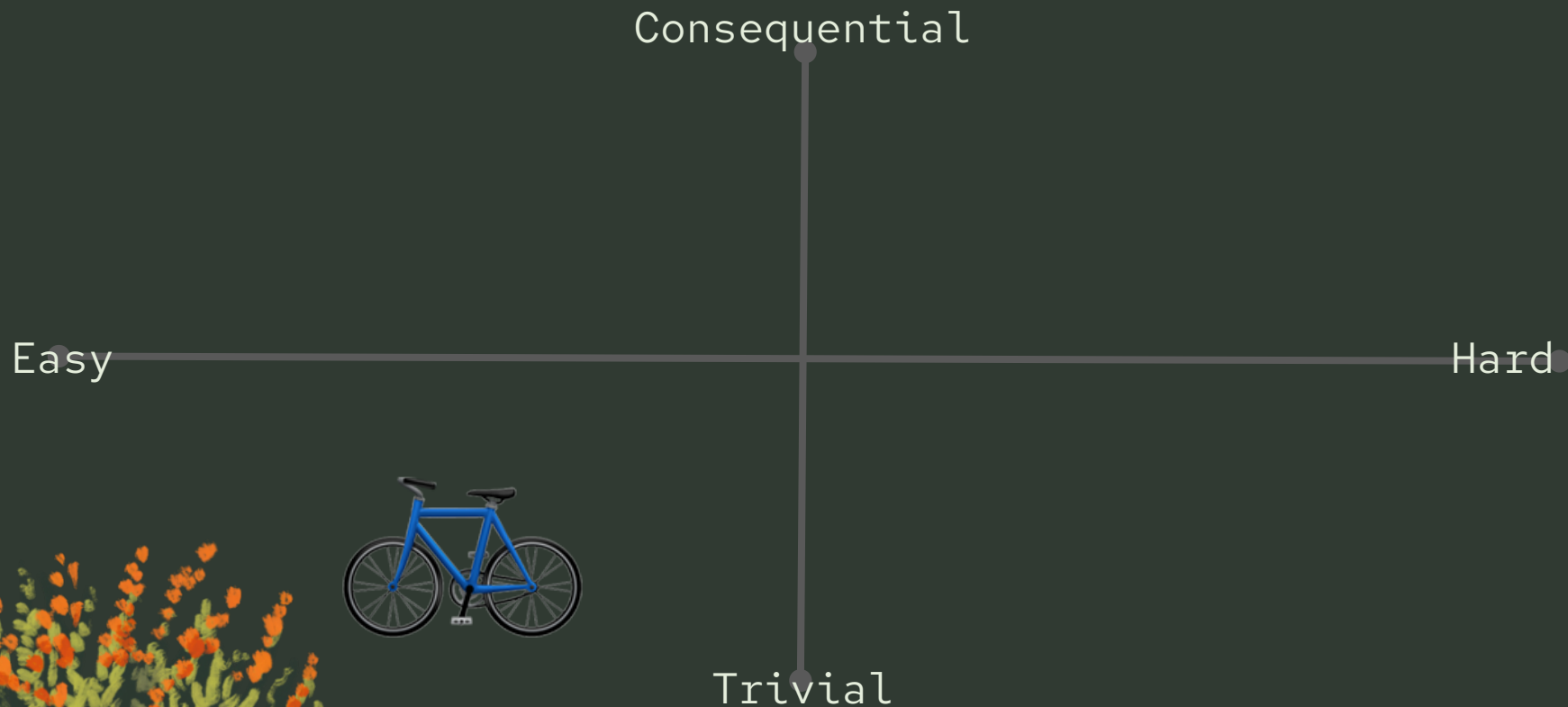
Dashboard

PULL_REQUEST_TEMPLATE.md





Law of Triviality



/pi-pr



Test plan

Smoke test

Using `Sidekiq::Testing.fake!` to capture enqueued jobs without executing them:

```
require "sidekiq/testing"; Sidekiq::Testing.fake!
```

```
setup = Testing::Invoicables::LocationGroupType.new(location_count: 1, cadence: :daily); ig = setup.new
```

```
GenerateInvoicePdfWorker.jobs.clear; InvoiceNotificationWorker.jobs.clear  
invoice = Invoicing::CreateInvoice.call(due_date: 30.days.from_now, invoice_group: ig, orders: orders)
```

Verify the worker was enqueued with `notify: true` (the default):

```
GenerateInvoicePdfWorker.jobs.last.slice("class", "args")
```

Expected: `{"class"=>"GenerateInvoicePdfWorker", "args"=>[<invoice_id>, true]}`

⚠ [Add console output here] ⚠

Test plan

Smoke test

Using `Sidekiq::Testing.fake!` to capture enqueued jobs without executing them:

```
require "sidekiq/testing"; Sidekiq::Testing.fake!
```

Generate billable orders & such:

```
setup = Testing::Invoicables::LocationGroupType.new(location_count: 1, cadence: :daily)
```

Setup invoice groups and orders to pass into the invoice creator:

```
ig = setup.default_invoice_group; orders = setup.send(:generate_orders, count: 1, currency: :USD)
```

Clear out the jobs (just in case):

```
GenerateInvoicePdfWorker.jobs.clear; InvoiceNotificationWorker.jobs.clear
```

► Click for output



Test plan

Console Verification

Find an active order:

```
order = Order.joins(:organization).where.not(status: "cancelled").last
```



► Click for output



Test plan

Console Verification

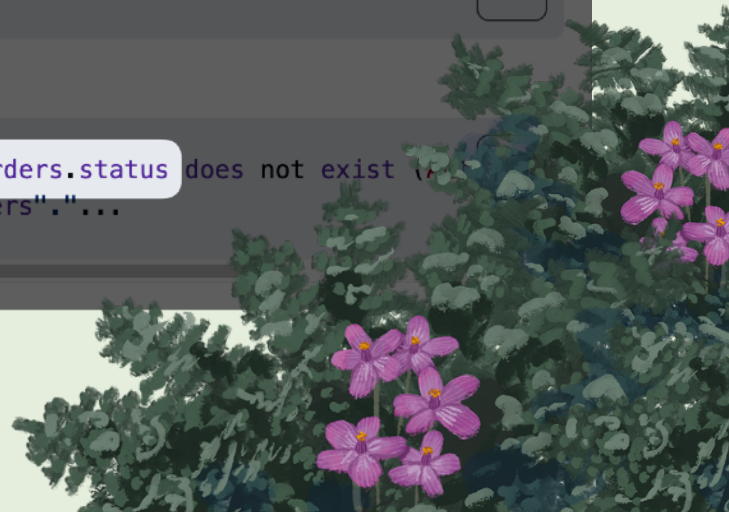
Find an active order:

```
order = Order.joins(:organization).where.not(status: "cancelled").last
```



▼ Click for output

```
(negotiatius):1:in '<main>': PG::UndefinedColumn: ERROR: column orders.status does not exist (A  
LINE 1: ...ation_id" WHERE "orders"."deleted_at" IS NULL AND "orders"."...
```



🙄 How many times must I tell you there is NOT a "status" column on  `order.rb` ?

No 🍕 party for you.

∞ Agent ▾

Opus 4.8 High ▾



Try Plan M



/pi-pr

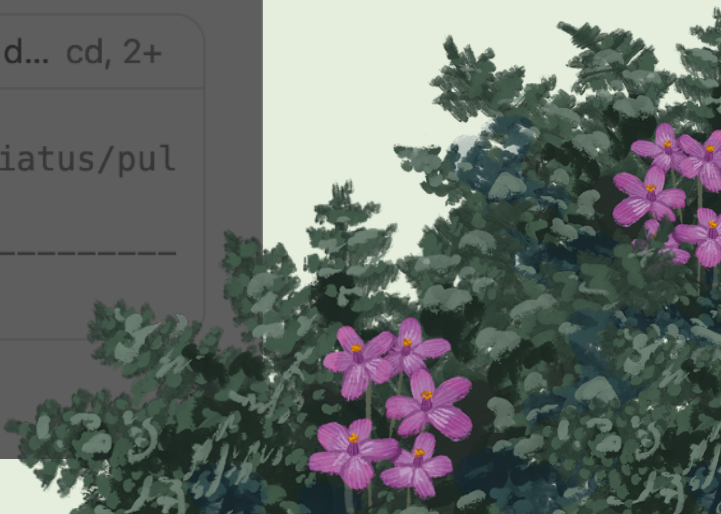
[github.com/Negotiatus/negotiatu...](https://github.com/Negotiatus/negotiatus)

```
branch : ms/PI-4004-misc-guideline-updates
ticket : PI-4004
commits: 8
files  : 8
```

Fetch related historical PRs touching these d... cd, 2+

```
https://github.com/Negotiatus/negotiatus/pul
l/16033
-----
-----
```

Planning next moves



/pi-pr

[github.com/Negotiatus/negotiatu...](https://github.com/Negotiatus/negotiatus)

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l/16033
-----
-----
```

Planning next moves



/pi-pr

github.com/Negotiatus/negotiatus

thought for us

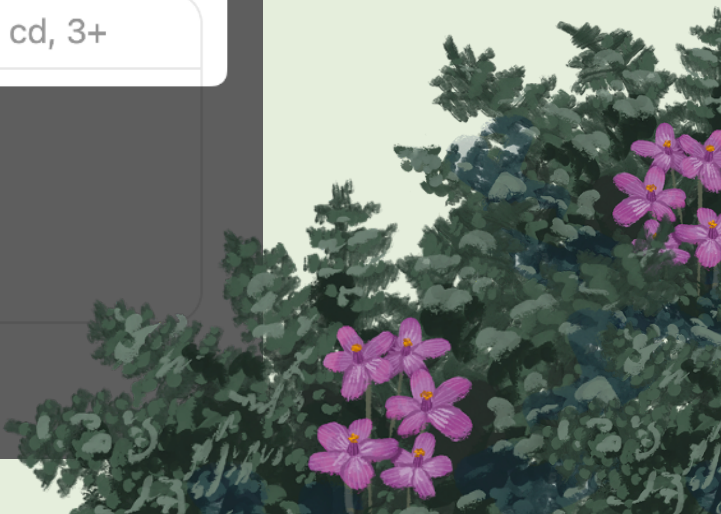
Two direct ancestors found, both touching these exact convention docs. Let me peek at how they structured their descriptions so this one stays consistent with the established pattern.

 View related PR bodies for structure insight cd, 3+

```
# Promote front-end conventions to  
docs/conventions/frontend/
```

```
## Purpose
```

Planning next moves





fix seeds #7864

 Merged



merged 2 commits into

master

from

TIDE-489/fix_seeds



on Nov 18, 2020



Conversation 1



Commits 2



Checks 0



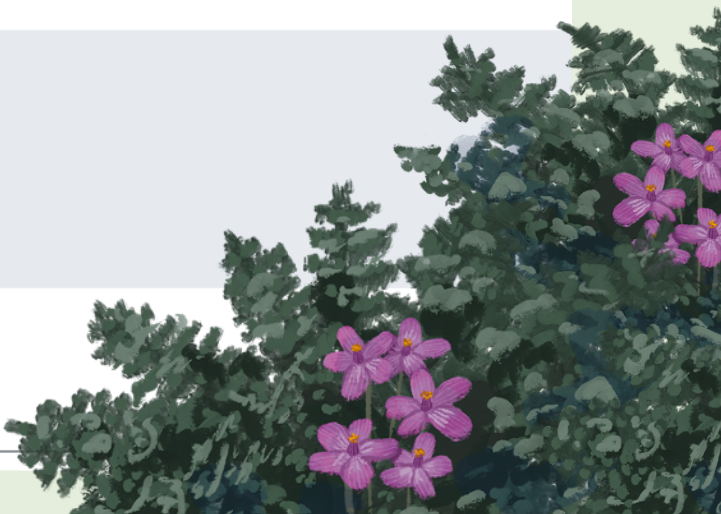
Files changed 2



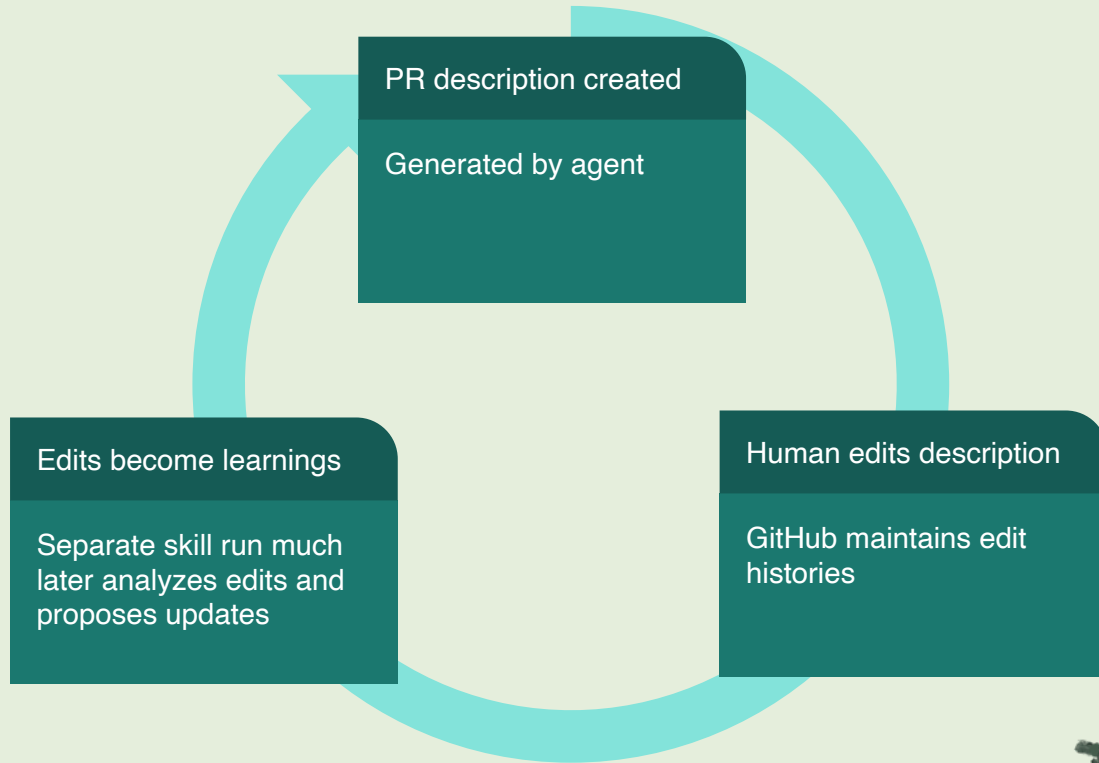
 commented on Nov 18, 2020 • edited ▾

Run rake db:setup

```
if   
  reject  
else  
    
end
```



review-retro skill





Conversation 1



Commits 2



Checks 1



Files changed 2



madisonsites commented on Apr 6 • edited by atlassian Bot ▼



Ticket: [PI-3619](#)

Incorporate PR description learnings (2026-04-06)

Purpose

- Analyzing edits made to pi-pr-generated descriptions after they merged surfaced 8 actionable learnings: 5 for `SKILL.md` (process rules) and 3 for `pull_request_guidelines.md` (formatting)

Leave It Better Than
You Found It



Leave It Better

A flywheel made visible

– **Better guidelines**



Leave It Better

A flywheel made visible

- Better guidelines
- **Better output**



Leave It Better

A flywheel made visible

- Better guidelines
- Better output
- **Better PRs**



Leave It Better

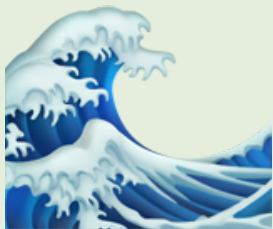
A flywheel made visible

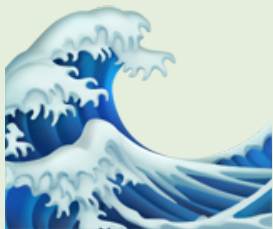
- Better guidelines
- Better output
- Better PRs
- **Better reference material**

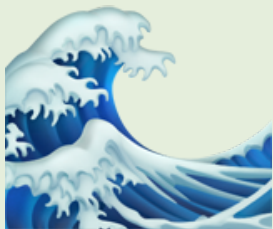


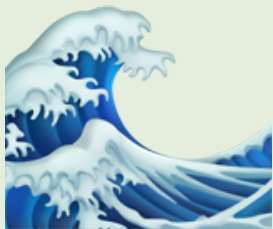
Code Review



















It's about the
✨context✨ we made
along the way



It's about the
✨context✨ we made
along the way

